



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

50-YEAR-OLD COASTAL ACT IN DANGER

An oil rig looms offshore as a surfer paddles off Santa Barbara County. The Trump administration is threatening to undo decades of shoreline protections in the state, Steve Lopez writes. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Warning against politics in research funding

President’s proposal would end the use of scientific merit to pick grants, critics say.

By CORINNE PURTILL

A new rule proposed by the White House Office of Management and Budget would fundamentally overhaul the way federal grants are awarded and overseen — a sweeping change that one scientific society said “would all but end the use of scientific merit in the selection of grants and programs across the government.”

Proposed in late May, the rule would give political appointees unprecedented control over federal grants for research, education and infrastructure, and specifies that government funds can be spent only on projects “aligned with administration policies and priorities,” according to a copy of the proposed rule.

The rule would also restrict research topics, limit U.S. scientists’ ability to collaborate with colleagues in other countries and make it easier for the government to suspend or cancel grants at any time.

The changes are intended to improve “transparency, accountability, and oversight for Federal awards” while “ensuring that American tax dollars are not wasted or misused,” according to the White House office.

But critics say that if the rule is implemented, the final sign-off for grants will no longer be in the hands of subject-matter experts within individual agencies, but in those of political appointees.

“This touches all parts of American life,” said Dr. Eric Rafla-Yuan, a psychiatrist who practices at the Veterans Administration and San Diego County’s psychiatric hospital.

“Control of how all of the federal grants and programs are funded will fall under a small group of highly partisan individuals who would have very few limits on how they spend these billions of taxpayer dollars,” said Rafla-Yuan, who also chairs the Committee to Protect Public Mental Health advocacy group. “This touches everyone’s life, even if they don’t realize it.”

OMB published the proposed rule May 29, opening a 45-day comment period that closes Monday.

Opposition to the proposed rule has mobilized [See **OMB**, A6]

Housing law may leave big mark on California

Supporters of the federal bill hope its dozens of tweaks can collectively improve affordability

By BEN CHRISTOPHER

The largest single piece of federal housing legislation to come out of Congress in at least a generation is now law.

It happened in the middle of the night early Saturday, without fanfare — or even President Trump’s signature — and it might be a while before many Californians notice its effects.

That’s because the bill, though politically monumental — both chambers approved it overwhelmingly — doesn’t do one big thing. Instead, it does a lot of little things. Individually, none of the bill’s 56 regulatory tweaks, pilot programs and low-cost loans and grants are likely to move the needle on the nation’s housing affordability woes, nor on California’s specifically.

Supporters hope that collectively, they just might.

Even the law’s path to enactment had an under-the-radar quality to it. The White House abruptly canceled a planned signing ceremony late last

month, with Trump vowing not to sign the bill until Congress first passed his restrictive national voter ID proposal. That bill has stalled out in the Senate.

Still, Trump did not veto the housing package, so it automatically became law Saturday just after midnight, as per the Constitution.

For all that, supporters say this is still a big deal: a major, bipartisan piece of legislation aimed at boosting housing construction from a hyperpartisan legislative body that doesn’t typically touch the topic.

“We don’t often gather to celebrate federal housing legislation,” Stephen Russell, president of the San Diego Housing Federation, said at a news conference Thursday. “I think the last time Congress passed anything of this magnitude, many of you were not even alive. ... It is almost a once-in-a-lifetime event.”

That’s thanks in part to a growing caucus of lawmakers aligned with the “Yes In My Backyard” movement that [See **Housing**, A6]

Hollywood debates meaning of ‘actor’ ahead of AI film debut

By JOSH ROTTENBERG

For most of Hollywood’s history, the word “actor” has required little explanation. Actors search for emotional truth in imaginary lives. They collaborate with directors and scene partners, endure 4 a.m. call times and, if everything goes right, thank their agents while collecting awards.

Tilly Norwood has done none of those things. That’s because Tilly exists only as code and pixels.

Last week’s announce-

ment that Tilly — the AI-generated character that debuted last year amid fierce backlash from actors and unions — would star in an upcoming feature called “Misaligned” sparked a debate not only about the impact of artificial intelligence on Hollywood jobs but about something even more basic: What, exactly, is Tilly? Some objected to referring to the digital character as “she” or “her.” Others rejected the idea that Tilly could be described as an actor at all.

The debate quickly spilled into readers’ com-

ments on The Times’ coverage of the project. One commenter urged journalists to “stop writing about this thing like it’s a person.” Another asked, “How is this not just an animated film?” A third objected: “She is NOT an AI Actor, she is an AI Software Program.” But not everyone recoiled. “I’ll buy a ticket,” one reader wrote. “She’s very pretty.”

Taken together, the reactions exposed just how unsettled the language around AI has become. Nobody has ever confused Woody from [See **Tilly**, A8]

Graham’s death further roils midterm races

His loss, along with McConnell’s absence, cuts into GOP’s edge and adds uncertainty.

By JUSTINE MCDANIEL

WASHINGTON — The sudden death of Sen. Lindsey Graham, the veteran South Carolina Republican lawmaker, is scrambling the state’s U.S. Senate race as Republicans face a fast primary election to replace him on the ballot.

Graham, 71, who died Saturday after what the D.C. medical examiner called an aorta rupture, was seeking a fifth term in the Senate. Even as his political allies publicly mourned his loss, jockeying began over the vacancy, and President Trump signaled an intention to weigh in.

“I have somebody that I think would be great, but I don’t want to say it now because it’s just, you know, it’s too soon with Lindsey,” Trump, who ordered American flags to be lowered to half-staff in Graham’s honor, said Sunday on NBC News’ “Meet the Press.” “I don’t want to even talk about anybody, but I do have somebody that I think is really good.”

Graham’s death eats into Republicans’ voting majority in the Senate, as does the absence of Sen. Mitch McConnell of Kentucky, who has been hospitalized for weeks. It adds new uncertainty for Republicans at a time when the party is contending with Trump’s declining popularity among Americans and tensions have been high among Senate Republicans at odds with Trump. [See **Graham**, A5]

OBITUARY: Graham was a foreign policy hawk and partisan yet known for political flexibility. **NATION, A4**

McCONNELL’S HEALTH: Kentucky senator breaks silence, says a fall led to his hospitalization. **NATION, A5**

Supreme Court originalists break with originalism

On issue of birthright citizenship, most conservatives rethink a long-held principle.

By DAVID G. SAVAGE

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court’s conservative justices say they decide cases based on the words and original history of the Constitution — and not on their personal or political views.

Following the lead set by the late Justice Antonin Scalia, they say they see history and originalism as a guiding principle to prevent judges from changing the Constitution to adjust to new and changing times.

This text-and-history approach is said to contrast with an evolving or “living Constitution” favored by progressives and liberal activists.

But this year saw a flip of sorts on birthright citizenship.

The foremost conservatives agreed with President Trump that the surge of illegal immigration called for reconsidering the promise of citizenship at birth set out in the 14th Amendment of 1868.

The opening words of the 14th Amendment of 1868 say: “All persons born or naturalized in the United States, and subject to the jurisdiction thereof, are citizens of the United States.”

“The number of illegal immigrants in this country exploded” in recent years, Justice Samuel A. Alito Jr. wrote in dissent. The rule of citizenship at birth provides “a powerful incentive to enter or remain in this country illegally,” he added.

“The Constitution is an enduring document,” wrote Justice Brett M. Kavanaugh, but its rules and meaning must adjust to “modern situations that were unknown or unanticipated by the Constitution’s Framers.”

In a concurring opinion, he said that “significant il- [See **Birthright**, A5]

U.S. renews strikes on Iran as standoff over strait escalates

By JON GAMBRELL, WILL WEISSERT AND KONSTANTIN TOROPIN

DUBAI — The United States launched several waves of strikes against Iran on Sunday over an Iranian attack on a container ship in the Strait of Hormuz that set it ablaze and left a crew member missing earlier in the weekend. Iran responded with attacks on Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Jordan and Oman — the nation on the other side of the strait that Tehran has pressed to collaborate in managing shipping traffic.

The U.S. military said it was seeking “to degrade” Iran’s “ability to attack commercial ships freely transiting” the vital waterway. The statement came after a third round of strikes late Sunday night and into Monday in Iran.

Iranian state media acknowledged the latest round early Monday but reported no casualties or damage to civilian infrastructure in the areas near the strait. It wasn’t immediately clear whether any military targets had been hit.

The first wave of strikes, on Sunday morning, was in response to an Iranian strike on a container ship in the strait the day before. In response, Iran hit gulf Arab states in an escalating cycle of violence that left the negotiations between Tehran and Washington to end the war at the edge of collapse.

The U.S. struck again later Sunday. The governor of Qeshm Island near the strait told the state-run Islamic Republic News Agency that projectiles were fired at military targets, with no casualties. Explosions were also heard in the coast- [See **Iran**, A3]

LAPD halts use of street cameras

Concerns about federal access to data lead to a suspension of Flock Safety’s vehicle trackers. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Sparks fire GM amid drab season

Raegan Pebley built a team just below the WNBA playoff cutoff line but far from title contention. **SPORTS, D1**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 85/67. **B6**

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EX-RULER OF QATAR DIES

Sheikh Hamad bin Khalifa al Thani, hoisting the World Cup in 2010, spent 18 years turning his tiny Persian Gulf nation into a global player. **WORLD, A3**